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AFP

CIVILIANS FLEE KURDISH AREAS OF ALEPPO AMID FIGHTING

■ Residents flee Aleppo's Ashrafiyah Kurdish neighbourhood yesterday. Civilians were asked to evacuate neighbourhoods of Aleppo after the Syrian army declared them 'closed military zones', amid ongoing fighting with Kurdish-led forces in the northern city. **SEE ALSO P7**

UAE to restrict salt in bakery, processed food

Move to reduce risk
of cardiovascular
diseases

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

The Ministry of Health and Prevention (MoHAP), will mandate maximum salt levels in bakery, packaged, and processed foods as part of a strategy to reduce the risk of cardiovascular diseases, a top official told *Gulf News*.

This follows alarming findings from the National Health and Nutrition Survey, which revealed that 96.2 per cent of

residents consume sodium well above recommended daily limits. "We need to control how much salt is used in bread, bakery products, and processed foods, with specific maximum percentages to be followed," Dr Hussain Abdul Rahman Al Rand, Assistant Undersecretary for the Public Health Sector at MoHAP, said.

Major contributor

Health officials warned that excessive sodium intake is a major contributor to high blood pressure, which affects 25.9 per cent of adults in the UAE as per the survey, and increases the risk of serious cardiovascular disease. Health officials also

noted that high-salt diets are closely linked to obesity, as salty foods stimulate appetite and are often consumed in calorie-dense processed and restaurant meals, compounding long-term health risks.

The ministry's approach will extend beyond bakeries to multiple food categories through a reformulation programme aimed at reducing salt, sugar, and fat content in everyday products. Unlike taxation that is already applied to sugary beverages and tobacco products, the ministry confirmed that salt will be addressed through reformulation requirements rather than additional taxes.

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Abu Dhabi targets Dh300 billion GDP boost, 110,000 jobs

CLUSTER-LED INVESTMENT MODEL
TO ENSURE LONG-TERM GROWTH

ABU DHABI

BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

Abu Dhabi's cluster-led investment strategy is targeting close to Dh300 billion in GDP contribution and more than 110,000 skilled jobs by 2045, according to a senior executive at the Abu Dhabi Investment Office (ADIO).

The emirate is overhauling how it measures investment success, moving away from headline capital inflows toward long-term economic impact, including industrial capacity, export growth, and skilled employment.

Outcomes over inflows

Ahmad Soubra, Head of Value Creation at ADIO, said success is no longer defined by how much capital enters the economy, but by what that capital builds once deployed. Indicators include factories operating at scale, engineers and researchers based locally, and multinational companies using Abu Dhabi as a base for production and innovation.

Under the Abu Dhabi Industrial Strategy, the manufacturing sector is targeted to contribute Dh172 billion to the economy by 2031, driven by deeper production, stronger exports, and domestic industrial development.

Cluster-led model

The approach aligns regulation, infrastructure, incentives, and workforce development

Dh172b
contribution of
manufacturing
sector to the
economy by 2031

around priority sectors to reduce execution risk and anchor high-value operations. Priority clusters span advanced manufacturing, smart and autonomous mobility, life sciences, agrifood and water technologies, and financial and digital platforms.

Backed by sovereign capital

Abu Dhabi's estimated \$1.7 trillion in sovereign capital underpins the strategy, with ADIO channelling that scale into structured ecosystems rather than standalone projects.

One platform, the Fintech, Insurance, Digital and Alternative Investments (FIDA) cluster, targets Dh56 billion in GDP and about 8,000 jobs, backed by Dh17 billion in planned investment.

Shifting investor base

Companies are increasingly establishing engineering centres, advanced manufacturing facilities, AI and data infrastructure, and life sciences platforms in Abu Dhabi. Long-horizon institutional capital and global asset managers are also building permanent operations.

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